Reading

a. Read the following passage.

"There's always room for a story that can transport people to another place."

- J.K.Rowling

Short stories capture human values evolving from wide ranging incidents and episodes. Each of the stories given below has a specific goal; to teach unique values that are truly valuable in life.

Positive Thinking

This **parable** is told of a farmer who owned an old mule. The mule fell into the farmer's well. The farmer heard the mule praying or whatever mules do when they fall into wells.

After carefully **assessing** the situation, the farmer sympathized with the mule, but decided that neither the mule nor the well was worth the trouble of saving. Instead, he called his neighbours together, told them what had happened, and **enlisted** them to help **haul** dirt to bury the old mule in the well and put him out of his misery.

Initially the old mule was **hysterical**! But as the farmer and his neighbours continued shovelling and the dirt hit his back, a thought struck him. It suddenly dawned on him that every time a shovel load of dirt landed on his back, HE WOULD SHAKE IT OFF AND STEP UP!

This he did, blow after blow. "Shake it off and step up… shake it off and step up… shake it off and step up!" He repeated to encourage himself. No matter how painful the blows, or how **distressing** the situation seemed, the old mule fought panic and just kept right on SHAKING IT OFF AND STEPPING UP!

It wasn't long before the old mule, **battered** and exhausted, stepped triumphantly over the wall of that well! What seemed like it would bury him actually helped him … all because of the manner in which he handled his adversity.

THAT'S LIFE! If we face our problems and respond to them positively, and refuse to give in to panic, bitterness, or self-pity, life becomes meaningful.

Selflessness

Once upon a time, there lived a big mango tree. A little boy loved to come and play around it every day.

He climbed to the tree top, ate the mangoes, and took a nap under the shade. He loved the tree and the tree loved to play with him.

Time went by… The little boy grew, and he no longer played around the tree.

One day, the boy came back to the tree with a sad look on his face.

"Come and play with me," the tree asked the boy.

"I am no longer a kid; I don't play around trees anymore." The boy replied, "I want toys. I need money to buy them."

"Sorry, I don't have money, but you can pick all my mangoes and sell them so you will have money."

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